Because the shell's air-filled inner chambers floated upward, ammonites swam with their heads beneath their bodies.

Bifericeras

BYE-fuh-ih-suh-ras

- **When** 200 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Europe
- **Habitat** Open seas
- **Size** 1¼ in (3 cm) across

Bifericeras fed on small invertebrates that lived in the seas. The larger shells ("macroconches") belonged to the females and the smaller ones ("microconches") to the males. Females needed larger body sizes for producing and protecting their eggs.

Microconch (male) fossil formed of the mineral iron pyrite ("fool's gold").

Macroconch (female)

Aturia

ay-TOO-ree-a

- **When** 65–23 million years ago (Paleogene to Early Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Open waters
- **Size** Up to 6 in (15 cm) across

Although the ammonites died out at the same time as the dinosaurs, closely related animals called nautiloids survived. *Aturia* was a fast-swimming nautiloid that probably preyed on fish and shrimp. Its shell was smooth and streamlined for speed, without the ribs seen in many ammonites.

LIVING RELATIVE

The pearly nautilus is a living nautiloid and a relative of the ammonites. Like its prehistoric cousins, it lives in a spiral shell divided into chambers, and it swims by squirting water. It has up to 90 tentacles, which it uses to capture small fish and crustaceans.